campaign aggressively or put up a tough candidate against Pawar's daughter Supriya or the NCP's high-profile minister Praful Patel.

Indeed, most corporates at election time prefer keeping their options open while funding political parties. In 2014, though, the balance of power had clearly shifted. No one wanted to divulge exact numbers, but one industrialist summed it up for me. 'If in 2009, we gave sixty paise to the Congress and forty paise to the BJP, this time, it's eighty paise to the BJP and twenty to the Congress.' The 2014 election was perhaps the first time in Indian electoral history that the Opposition was getting more funding than the ruling party.

When a businesswoman met Sonia Gandhi at the height of the 2014 campaign in April, the Congress president looked troubled. 'I don't think something like this has ever happened to the Congress party in any election,' she said. 'We are struggling to raise money.'

Motilal Vora, the octogenarian treasurer of the Congress party, was getting desperate. The Congress's cash cow state in 2009 had been Andhra Pradesh, but its main fundraiser Y.S. Rajasekhar Reddy was now dead. In Maharashtra, Prithviraj Chavan didn't have the rugged ability of his predecessors to get the state's powerful builder lobby to contribute to the party. Haryana and Karnataka were the only Congress-ruled states that could be tapped for funds. 'Even individual Congress leaders who had acquired large personal wealth weren't willing to help,' claims one Congress office-bearer, adding, 'the public was knocking us for being corrupt, but even this so-called corrupt party was short of cash.'

In fact, one senior Congress minister who had contested several elections rang up Vora seeking funding for his campaign. 'But you are such a wealthy man, why do you need money?' the beleaguered treasurer asked. 'Well, every rupee counts!' was the unashamed answer.

Ahmed Patel, who had handled the party's funding for years, then stepped in. He rang up several top industrialists. One of them told him, 'Yes, sir, we will definitely give money, but you know how business is at the moment.' Another corporate leader who had felt unfairly drawn into a legal tangle by the CBI was more direct. 'When I needed you, no one